CHAPTER 1

Final particles

1.1 INTRODUCTION

In many Sinitic languages, there are short, usually unstressed expressions grammatically bound to the end of a clause or sentence to facilitate conversational interactions (Cheung 1972; Luke 1990; Law 1990; Fang 2003; Tang 1998, 2015, 2020; Wakefield 2020; Pan 2021; among others). They are often optional for grammaticality, but required if the specific nuance or discourse function they encode is to be expressed. I follow Fung (2000) and refer to them as final particles (or FPs).

This chapter takes up final particles in Cantonese, two examples of which are *ne1*, as shown in (1), and *aa3*, as shown in (2). They are glossed with approximate discourse functions, to be discussed in more detail in section 1.4, and translated into English using semantically similar expressions.[1]

(1) Siufan heoi-zo bin **ne1**?
Siufan go-PFV where ROGATIVE
'Where did Siufan go, **I wonder**?'

(2) Siufan heoi-zo bin **aa3**?
Siufan go-PFV where DYNAMIC
'**Hey**, where did Siufan go?'

There are about 30 - 40 monosyllabic final particles in Cantonese (Kwok 1984; Sybesma & Li 2007, a.o.) These particles combine to form about 100 common final particle combinations, or final particle clusters (Luke 1990; Zhang 2014). Early research on final particles, such as Kwok (1984), Luke (1990) and Fung (2000), was conducted within a **lexicalist** approach, which emphasized the functions of individual particles. However, there has been growing interest in a **syntactic** approach, informed by the neo-performative hypothesis. (Lam 2014; Tang 2020; Pan 2021; Law 2024; see also Wiltschko 2021; Miyagawa 2022).

This chapter situates the neo-performative hypothesis in the broader discourse grammar to study final particles in Cantonese. Although the neo-performative hypothesis is developed in 'formal linguistics' for the study of single utterances while discourse gram-

[1] The glossing conventions for final particles are as follows: *aa3*: DYNAMIC, *ge3*: PERSONAL EVIDENCE (PERS.EV), *le5*: INSISTENCE, *lo1*: EXCESSIVE, *maa3*: POLAR QUESTION (PQ), *me1*: OPPOSITE BIAS POLAR QUESTION (OBIASPQ), *ne1*: ROGATIVE, *tim*: ADDITIVE. *wo3*: CONCESSIVE

mar was developed in ‘functional linguistics’ for the study of discourse and text, they share striking similarities suggestive of a common core: they both place heavy emphasis on **hierarchical organization** and **sensitivity to context** (Hengeveld & Mackenzie 2008; Mann & Thompson 1987; Murray & Starr 2021). Drawing on final particles in Cantonese, I argue that these similarities are not merely analogical but reflect a shared underlying analysis. Concretely, it is argued that the hierarchical structure and context sensitivity developed for discourse grammar is well suited for modeling the hierarchical structure for utterances with final particles. I refer to this view as **Illocution-Discourse Alignment**.

At the core of this alignment is the following idea: Units of representation widely accepted in discourse grammar, including clauses, sentences, utterances, and discourse, as informally defined in Table 1.1, are meaningful units that can host final particles. The distribution and function of final particles depend on the syntax and semantics of their hosts, determined compositionally.[2] A welcome result of this move is a **more transparent nomenclature**—terms like clause-final particles, sentence-final particles, utterance-final particles, and discourse particles are in fact meaningfully distinct and should no longer be used inter-changeably.

unit	**definition**
clause	propositional content
sentence	*independent* proposition content
utterance	use of independent propositional content by an agent in a situation, with intentions
discourse	sequence of utterances and their relations

Table 1.1 Definitions of clauses, sentences, utterances, and discourse

Another welcome result is that final particles form classes based on their **sub-categorization properties**. We expect final particles that sub-categorize for clauses to have properties different from those that sub-categorize for sentences or utterances.

To facilitate the discussion, a sentence containing a final particle is partitioned into two parts: a *host* and a final particle (FP), as shown in (3-a). The host is defined as the constituent to which a final particle attaches. Since final particles can form clusters, a host may contain a final particle but still counts as a host for another final particle, as shown in (3-b). In this case, the final particles *ne1* and *ho2* may have distinct sub-categories, if they happen to select different types of hosts.

(3) a. $\overbrace{\text{Siufan heoi-zo bin}}^{\text{Host}}\,\overbrace{\textbf{ne1}}^{\text{FP}}$? — single final particle

b. $\overbrace{\text{Siufan heoi-zo bin }\textbf{ne1}}^{\text{Host2 = Host1 + FP1}}\,\overbrace{\textbf{ho2}}^{\text{FP2}}$? — final particle cluster

Final particles sub-categorizing for different types of hosts roughly serve the functions summarized in Table 1.2.

While not the primary focus of this chapter, it is worth noting that the proposed parallelism between the hierarchical organization of final particles and that of discourse is

[2] In this chapter, the discussion of compositionality remains informal for accessibility. A formal compositional approach will be developed in future research.

final particle	**function**
clause-final	highlight parts of a propositional content
sentence-final	turn a propositional content to an utterance
utterance-final	chain utterances to form discourse

Table 1.2 Sub-categories of Cantonese final particles and their functions

also supported by existing studies on the interaction between final particles and intonation. Since Law (1990), intonation on final particles has been argued to play a relatively independent role from final particles themselves, contributing its own pragmatic meaning at the utterance level (Zhang & Tang 2016; Ki & Lau 2019; Tang 2020; Lee 2021; Lee 2024, among others). In this sense, intonation can also compose with the meanings of final particles to yield the overall pragmatic effect conveyed by an utterance.

The rest of the article is organized as follows to support these claims. section 1.2 shows that hierarchical structure has been argued to play a central role in both discourse organization and the organization of final particles. This parallel motivates the hypothesis that classical models of discourse structure can be adapted to the study of final particles. The hypothesis is then tested with the help of final particles in Cantonese, from section 1.3 to section 1.5. Section 1.6 concludes.

1.2 UNIFYING TWO DISCOURSE HIERARCHIES

1.2.1 Layered discourse structure

Based on extensive cross-linguistic research, scholars like Mann & Thompson (1987), Büring (2003), and Hengeveld & Mackenzie (2008) argue that discourse is hierarchically organized. An important part of this hierarchical organization lies in units like **clauses**, **sentences**, **utterances**, and **discourse** (Huddleston & Pullum 2002; Crystal 2008).

(4)
a. **clause**: a unit in which a predicate and all of its arguments have been specified
b. **sentence**: abstract, grammatically complete string of words
c. **utterance**: concrete, contextualized use of a sentence by a speaker in a specific situation
d. **discourse**: concrete, a sequence of utterances and their relations

A clause is typically taken to be a representation in which a predicate has been furnished with all of its arguments. A clause can be subordinate or matrix. For example, *Mingzai sik min* 'Mingzai eats noodles' is a subordinate clause in (5), but a matrix clause in (6).

(5) Jyugwo Mingzai sik min, daai keoi heoi san hoi ge Sei.Ze.
if Mingzai eat noodles, bring him to newly open MOD Special.Noodle
'If Mingzai eats noodles, bring him to the newly-opened Special Noodle.'

(6) Mingzai sik min.
Mingzai sik noodle
'Mingzai eats noodles.'

Discourse
|
Utterance
|
Sentence
|
Clause

Figure 1.1 Layered discourse structure

A clause that can stand on its own, typically a matrix clause, is also a sentence. A sentence is usually taken to be abstract, because it is not tied to any concrete speaker, addressee, or conversational situation (modulo indexicals and deictic expressions). In somewhat simplified words, what matters for a sentence is whether it is true or not, but not who says it to whom in what context.

Utterances, on the other hand, are more concrete than sentences. An utterance is said by a particular speaker in a particular conversational situation. What matters for an utterance is often not whether it is true or false, but who uses it, to whom, with what intentions, and in what conversational situation.

Discourse is often defined as a sequence of utterances, hung together by discourse relations or discourse structure. In writing, it roughly corresponds to a paragraph. In other studies, it is sometimes referred to as a *move* (Mann & Thompson 1987).

These concepts are hierarchically organized, as in Figure 1.1. The hierarchical organization is *functionally* based—a discourse necessarily contains at least an utterance; an utterance necessarily contains a sentence; a sentence necessarily contains a clause.

1.2.2 Layered final particles

Final particles in Cantonese have also been argued to exhibit hierarchical structure, motivated by the presence of final particle clusters. For example, scholars working within the Split-CP Hypothesis have argued that final particles in Cantonese exhibit the following hierarchical structures:

(7) a. Event (*sin1*) < Temporal (*gam3zai3*) < Focus (*o/e/a*) < Degree (*ho2*) < COA (Rising intonation)[3] (Tang 2020)
b. Speaker Force (*ge3/me1/ne1*) < Addressee Force (*ho2*) (Lam 2014; Wiltschko 2021)
c. Sentence force (*ge3/me1/ne1*) < Participant quantifier (*ho2*) (Law 2024)

Each hierarchical organization is motivated by a subset of particles and some aspects of their functions. While each hierarchical organization may be descriptively useful, it raises the question why a particular hierarchy should be favored over the others. This question becomes even more pressing when we zoom out of Cantonese to look at other languages

[3] According to Tang (2020), rising intonation occupying COA attracts the movement of *ho2* from Degree.

with final particles. For example, final particles in Mandarin have been used to motivate a variety of hierarchical structures, some of which differ from the Cantonese hierarchies substantially:

(8) a. Focus < Degree < Emotion (Tang 2010; Tang 2015)
b. S.AspP < OnlyP < iForceP < SQP < AttP2 < AttP1 (Pan 2015)
c. Low SFP < C < Attitude (Erlewine 2017)

To the extent that final particles exhibit cross-linguistically stable characteristics, a more general model for understanding the hierarchical organization of these particles is called for.

Against this background, I propose that the hierarchical organization of final particles mirrors the hierarchical organization of discourse units. On this view, final particles are hierarchically organized because the discourse units that host them are hierarchically organized. Accordingly, final particles can (at least) be classified as clause-final, sentence-final, or utterance-final.

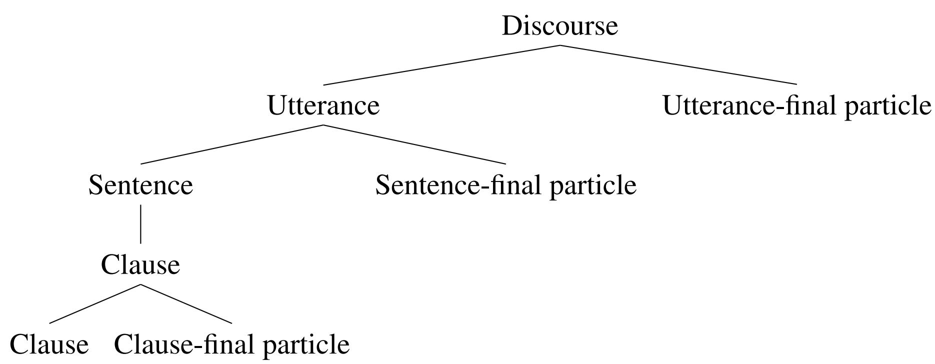

Figure 1.2 Hierarchical organization of final particles

The category a particle belongs in is to be understood in terms of **subcategorization**. Clause-final particles select clauses as their complements and return clauses, sentence-final particles select sentences as their complements and turn them into utterances, and utterance-final particles relate multiple utterances to form discourse.

1.3 CLAUSE-FINAL PARTICLE

A clause-final particle may attach to units that are smaller than sentences, like subordinate clauses. Cantonese has a few particles that may occur at the clausal level:

(9) Jyugwo Mingzai sik min **ge3**, zau daai keoi heoi Sei.Ze
if Mingzai eat noodles PERS.EV, then bring him to Special.Noodle
'If Mingzai eats noodles, take him to Special Noodle.'

(10) Jyugwo Mingzai sik min **tim1**, zau daai keoi heoi Sei.Ze
if Mingzai eat noodles ADDITIVE, then bring him to Special.Noodle
'If Mingzai also eats noodles, take him to Special Noodle.'

These particles can also stack and form clusters at the clausal level, in the following order:

(11) Jyugwo Mingzai sik min **tim1** **ge3**, zau daai keoi heoi
if Mingzai eat noodles ADDITIVE PERS.EV, then bring him to
Sei.Ze
Special.Noodle
'If it is the case that Mingzai also eats noodles, take him to Special Noodle.'

Clause-final particles are compatible with declarative clause types, as shown above, and interrogative clause types, as shown below:

(12) Mouleon4 Mingzai sik-m-sik min **ge3**, dou daai keoi heoi
Regardless Mingzai eat-not-eat noodles PERS.EV, then bring him to
Sei.Ze
Special.Noodle
'Whether Mingzai eats noodles or not, take him to Special Noodle.'

(13) Mouleon4 Mingzai sik-m-sik di min **tim1**, dou daai keoi heoi
Regardless Mingzai eat-not-eat some noodles PERS.EV, then bring him to
Sei.Ze
Special.Noodle
'Whether Mingzai eats noodles or not, take him to Special Noodle.'

This suggests that clause-final particles are not clause-typing devices—they do not serve the function of indicating particular clause types. This is likely because clause types are indicated by clause-internal morpho-syntax: declaratives are unmarked, interrogatives are marked by *wh*-phrases or A-not-A constituents, imperatives are marked by the absence of the subject.

Clause-final particles can also occur in a matrix clause, which creates the impression that they are sentence-final particles:

(14) Mingzai sik min **tim1/ge3**.
Mingzai eat noodles ADDITIVE/PERS.EV
a. tim1: 'Mingzai also eats noodles.'
b. ge3: 'It is the case that Mingzai eats noodles.'

In summary, clause-final particles attach to both subordinate and matrix clauses. They do not determine clause types and are compatible with a variety of clause types that do not conflict with their semantic contributions. We do not go to details about their functions. However, based on the literature, these particles often mark aspect (to highlight relevant parts of a situation) and focus (to indicate additivity and exclusivity). Since these are highlighting functions, clause-final particles are also referred to as 'highlighting particles.'

1.4 SENTENCE-FINAL PARTICLE

If clause-final particles take clauses as their host, and sentences are larger units of representation than clauses, then sentence-final particles should attach to hosts that contain clause-final particles. Using *ge3* as a clause-final particle, we identify a group of sentence-final particles, as shown below:[4]

(15) Mingzai sik min **ge3** **me1**?
Mingzai eat noodles PERS.EV OBIASPQ
'Is it **really** the case that Mingzai ate noodles? **(I doubt that's true.)**'

(16) Mingzai sik min **ge3** **maa3**?
Mingzai eat noodles PERS.EV PQ
'**Is it the case that** Mingzai eats noodles?'

(17) Mingzai sik-m-sik min **ge3** **ne1**?
Mingzai eat-not-eat noodles PERS.EV ROGATIVE
'**Is it the case** that Mingzai ate noodles, **I wonder**?'

(18) Mingzai sik-m-sik min **ge3** **aa3**?
Mingzai eat-not-eat noodles PERS.EV DYNAMIC
'**Hey**, **is it the case that** Mingzai eats noodles?'

(19) Mingzai sik min **ge3** **aa3**.
Mingzai eat noodles PERS.EV DYNAMIC
'**Hey**, **it is the case that** Mingzai eats noodles.'

Since they are sentence-final particles, these final particles do not occur in subordinate clauses:

(20) *Jyugwo Mingzai sik min **ge3** **me1/maa3/aa3**, zau daai keoi heoi
if Mingzai eat noodles PERS.EV NEG/PO/DYNAMIC, then bring him to
Sei.Ze
Special.Noodle
Intended. 'If Mingzai eats noodles, take him to Special Noodle.'

(21) *Mouleon Mingzai sik-m-sik min **ge3** **ne1/aa3**, dou
Regardless Mingzai eat-not-eat noodles PERS.EV ROGATIVE/DYNAMIC, then
daai keoi heoi Sei.Ze
bring him to Special.Noodle
Intended. 'Whether Mingzai eats noodles or not, take him to Special Noodle.'

In the next two subsections, we show that these sentence-final particles serve two functions: social and illocutionary.

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[4]A reviewer points out that there may be individual variation in the acceptability of the cluster *ge3-maa3*. Nevertheless, the following examples from the internet confirm that such a combination is indeed attested.

(i) Ceng2 man6 fo3tong4 hai6 min5fai3 ge3 maa3
please ask class be free PERS.EV PQ
'May I ask whether the class is free?' (`https://www.instagram.com/reel/C1eklPYvL4x/`)

(ii) Baat3gwaa3 geng3 zan1hai6 ho2ji5 po3 mai4zoeng3 ge3 maa3?
bagua mirror really can break illusion.obstacle PERS.EV PQ
'Can Bagua mirrors really dispel illusions/obstacles?'

1.4.1 Illocutionary effects

Illocutionary effects are determined by two factors: clause type and sentence-final particle type. A declarative sentence may be used as a polar question or an assertion, depending on the sentence-final particle type. If the particle is *me1* or *maa3*, a polar question is formed:

(22) Mingzai sik min **ge3** **me1**?
Mingzai eat noodles PERS.EV OBIASPQ
'Is it the case that Mingzai ate noodles, I wonder?'

(23) Mingzai sik min **ge3** **maa3**?
Mingzai eat noodles PERS.EV PQ
'**Is it the case that** Mingzai eats noodles.'

If there is no particle or if the particle is *aa3*, an assertion is formed:

(24) Mingzai sik min (**ge3**) (**aa3**).
Mingzai eat noodles PERS.EV DYNAMIC
'**Hey**, **it is the case that** Mingzai eats noodles.'

If the clause type is interrogative, then a question is formed, with or without any particle:

(25) Mingzai sik-m-sik min (**ge3**) (**ne1**)?
Mingzai eat-not-eat noodles PERS.EV ROGATIVE
'**Is it the case** that Mingzai ate noodles, **I wonder**?'

(26) Mingzai sik-m-sik min (**ge3**) (**aa3**)?
Mingzai eat-not-eat noodles PERS.EV DYNAMIC
'**Hey is it the case that** Mingzai eats noodles?'

The fact that declaratives and interrogatives naturally yield assertions and questions suggest that the particles do not contribute specific illocutionary force. Rather, they contribute *default* illocutionary force, also known as conventional discourse effects (Ginzburg & Sag 2000; Ginzburg 2012; Farkas & Roelofsen 2017).

An acute reader may notice two things. First, there is more than one particle representing each type of illocutionary force. Polar question force is marked by *me1* and *maa3*, while default force is associated with *ne1* and *aa3*. Second, these sentence-final particles involve two vowels: /-e/ and /-aa/. In the next subsection, it is shown that these observations are related.

1.4.2 Social functions

The /-e/-/-aa/ alternation correlates with an important distinction in addressee engagement: the /-e/ particles, namely, *me1* and *ne1*, may be used without an interlocutor-addressee. In other words, they can be used in self-directed utterances. However, the particle *aa3* must be used with an interlocutor-addressee. In the rest of this subsection, we use a monologue context and a dialogue context to diagnose the interlocutor-addressee requirement.

1.4.2.1 Monologue context

A monologue context is created to rule out the possibility of an interlocutor-addressee in a conversational situation. The context is as follows:

Monologue context
As a **sole survivor** of a shipwreck, you have been washed onto a small uninhabited island.

Scene 1: A-not-A question
You are hungry and looking for something to eat. Ahead, you notice a shrub covered with brightly colored berries. You move closer to examine them, murmuring to yourself as you do:

(27) Sik-m-sik-dak **ge3** **ne1**?
eat-not-eat-can PERS.EV WONDER
'Is this edible, **I wonder**?'

(28) #Sik-m-sik-dak **ge3** **aa3**?
eat-not-eat-can PERS.EV DYNAMIC
'**Hey**, is this edible?'

Scene 2: Assertion
The berries smell sweet and look like tiny grapes. Hunger gnawing at you, you murmur:

(29) Jinggoi hai sik-dak **ge3**.
should be eat-can PERS.EV
'It should be edible.'

(30) #Jinggoi hai sik-dak **ge3** **aa3**.
should be eat-can PERS.EV DYNAMIC
'Hey, it should be edible.'

Scene 3: Biased polar question
You taste one of the berries and find it intensely sour. Just then, a bird lands on the bush and begins pecking at the berries, apparently enjoying them. You look down at the berries in your hand and murmur:

(31) Hou sik **me1**?
good taste OBIASPQ
'Does this really taste good?'

(32) #Hou sik **maa3**?
good taste PQ
'Does this really taste good?'[5] As shown in the examples above, /-e/ particles are compatible with monologues while /-aa/ particles are not.

[5] A reviewer asked if the unacceptability of this example could be due to a potential anti-biased requirement of *maa3*. It is not clear to me that *maa3* has an anti-biased requirement. Observe that it can be used in the following biased context:
Context: You tasted some berries and found them to be tasty. You gave the same berries to a friend and they also seemed to like them. You ask:

1.4.3 Dialogue context

All the utterances, regardless of whether they have an /-e/ particle or an /-aa/ particle, are acceptable in a context in which an interlocutor addressee is present. To verify this, the following dialogue context is used:

Dialogue context
As the only **two survivors** of a shipwreck, you and your friend Chuck, who is a botanist, have been washed onto a small uninhabited island.

Scene 1: A-not-A question
You are both hungry and looking for food. Ahead, you both notice a shrub covered with brightly colored berries. The two of you move closer to examine them. Since you know very little about berries, you turn to Chuck and ask:

(33) Sik-m-sik-dak **ge3** **ne1**?
eat-not-eat-can PERS.EV ROGATIVE
'Is this edible?'

(34) Sik-m-sik-dak **ge3** **aa3**?
eat-not-eat-can PERS.EV DYNAMIC
Intended 'Is this edible?'

Scene 2: Assertion
The berries smell sweet and look like small grapes. Chuck, who knows plants well, says:

(35) Jinggoi hai sik-dak **ge3**.
should be eat-can PERS.EV
'It should be edible.'

(36) Jinggoi hai sik-dak **gaa3**.
should be eat-can DYNAMIC
'It should be edible.'

Scene 3: Biased polar question
You taste the berries and find them to be very sour. However, Chuck seems to like them. You look at Chuck and ask:

(37) Hou sik **me1**?
good taste OBIASPQ
'Does this really taste good?'

(38) Hou sik **maa3**?
good taste PQ
'Does this taste good?'

(i) Hou sik maa3?
good taste PQ
'Does this really taste good?'

1.4.4 Summary

The discussion so far suggests that sentence-final particles in Cantonese serve both an illocutionary and a social function. Inspired by the decompositional approach advocated by Law (1990), Fung (2000), Li (2006), and Sybesma & Li (2007), I propose that the illocutionary function is determined by the initial consonant, while the social function is determined by the vowel following the initial consonant.[6] Based on these functions, sentence-final particles are also called 'social-illocutionary particles'.

initial/vowel	e	aa
m	self-directed polar question	addressee-directed polar question
n	self-directed *wh*-question	–
ʔ	–	addressee-directed default force

Table 1.3 Social-illocutionary decomposition of sentence-final particles

1.5 UTTERANCE-FINAL PARTICLES

If clause-final particles highlight parts of a propositional content, sentence-final particles contribute social-illocutionary functions, then a natural function for utterance-final particles is to facilitate the integration of an utterance into the bigger discourse.

Utterances are integrated into discourse with the help of **rhetorical relations** (Mann & Thompson 1987). If utterance-final particles indeed facilitate utterance integration, then their functions can in principle be understood in terms of rhetorical relations. We argue that this is indeed the case.

First, utterance-final particles, unlike sentence-final particles, cannot be used discourse initially (see Fung 2000:111). For example, *zousan* 'good morning' can be used as a greeting out of the blue in the morning. However, it cannot be used with particles like *wo3*, *le5*, or *lo1*:

(39) zousan (#wo3/le5/lo1)
morning CONCESSIVE
'Good morning.'

The use of these particles always requires a prior utterance, which is reminiscent of the two-part nucleus-satellite structure Mann & Thompson (1987) suggest for discourse relations.

Second, quite a few final particles can be understood in terms of discourse relations. For example, the particle *wo3* can be used to indicate **concession**, which is an important discourse relation (Mann & Thompson 1987):

[6] Tones also play a role. For example, tone 4 predominantly yields questions when the vowel is *aa*, as in *aa4*, *laa4*, *gaa4*, and *zaa4*. However, when the vowel is not *aa*, tone 4 does not reliably yield questions, as in *wo4* (unecpectedness), *le4* (suggestion), *lo4* (evidential). In Sybesma & Li 2007, it is proposed that *aa4* cannot be decomposed futher and must be treated as a question particle. The role of tone is reserved for future research, but I thank a reviewer for sharing their observations.

(40) Speaker 1: Singkeiluk jatcai sik faan?
Saturday together eat rice
'Let's get together on Saturday?'

(41) Speaker 2: Ngo jiu gaa baan **wo3**.
I need extra work CONCESSIVE
'**But** I need to work.'

The particle *le5* indicates the discourse relation **restatement**, which is also discussed in Mann & Thompson (1987).

(42) Speaker 1: Ngo m-seon!
I not-believe
'I don't believe it!'

(43) Speaker 2: Ngo zenghai jiu gaa baan **le2**.
I indeed need extra work INSIST
'I **really** need to work.'

As Ginzburg (2012) points out, rhetorical relations as studied in Mann & Thompson (1987) heavily focuses on text, which is closer to monologues. However, utterance-final particles indicate discourse relations that are found in **dialogues**. So, it is expected that some particles would indicate discourse relations that are not commonly discussed in monologues. *Lo1* is such an example. It marks that the prior utterance is **excessive**, given the current utterance:

(44) Speaker 1: Lei heoi bin **aa3**?
you go where DYNAMIC
'Where are you going?'

(45) Speaker 2: Hokhaau **lo1**.
school OBVIOUS
'To school, **duh**.'

Since utterance-final particles help integrate utterances into discourse, they are also referred to as 'integration particles.'

1.6 CONCLUSION

This paper proposes a discourse-based model for final particles in Cantonese, as summarized in Figure 1.3. The core of the proposal is the parallelism between the hierarchical organization of final particles and the hierarchical organization of discourse. The model makes correct predictions about the distribution and the functions of final particles in Cantonese: clause-final particles are used to highlight parts of propositional content, sentence-final particles are used to turn sentences into utterances, as illocutionary acts, and utterance-final particles introduce discourse relations to integrate utterances into the bigger discourse. To what extent this model should be extended beyond Cantonese requires more cross-linguistic research.

As one reviewer notices, interjections may constitute a natural extension of the pro-

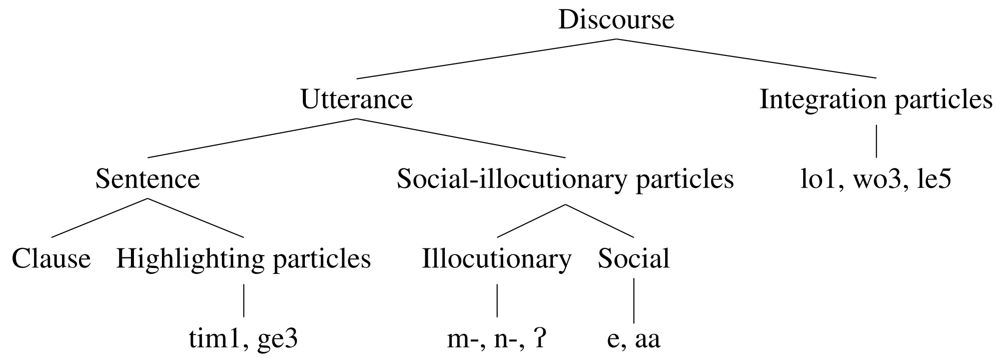

Figure 1.3 Hierarchical structure for final particles discussed discussed in this chapter

posed framework. Structurally, interjections appear to fall into two types: those that can function as independent utterances in discourse (e.g., o[353]), and those that are parasitic on a host utterance (e.g., wei[32], naa[21], etc.). Crucially, the primary function of interjections is to convey pragmatic effects, and Yip & Ki (2024) propose a decompositional approach to interjections analogous to that developed for final particles. Under this perspective, the proposed discourse-level compositional framework may also be extended to investigate the pragmatic meanings contributed by interjections in discourse.

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